Bogolo Joy Kenewendo

(ken-uh-WEN-doh)

Minister of Minerals and Energy
Republic of Botswana

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Nov 2024**

Bogolo Kenewendo is a trailblazing leader who harnesses her star power and economic expertise to promote Botswana's minerals and energy sector.

- **A Globe-Trotting Star**
  Kenewendo has been a favorite at global forums and think tanks events, wowing audiences with her poise, accessibility, and insights on climate, development, and gender issues.

- **An Accomplished Economist**
  The Minister has several economic degrees and worked in the private sector as a trade economist and bank board member. In an earlier stint as Minister of Investment, Trade and Industry, she implemented reforms to improve the ease of doing business and open up domestic and international markets.

Kenewendo first broke barriers in 2018 when, at age 30, she became Botswana's youngest government minister. As a young, female leader, Kenewendo noted the importance of delivering "results that speak for themselves."

WHY THEY MATTER

Kenewendo is committed to realizing a better deal for Botswana, leveraging her country's resources to rework unfair contracts while positioning the economy for a post-diamond future.

- **Negotiating for Results**
  She recently closed the landmark 10-year sales agreement with De Beers, increasing Okavango Diamond Company's share of production to 30% initially, rising to 50% by the deal's end. She has said the country needs "partners who are willing to grow with us, not just profit from us."

- **Diversifying the Economy**
  She has prioritized efforts to reduce Botswana's reliance on diamond mining. She has identified renewable energy, manufacturing, and agriculture as promising growth sectors for the country.

Kenewendo is a well-regarded thought leader on Africa's climate challenges, which has informed her views as mining and energy minister. She has emphasized that Africa's climate response must address energy access alongside emissions reductions.

MEETING WITH THEM

Kenewendo is a formidable interlocutor, brimming with the confidence and personal charisma to consistently win over counterparts.

- **Policy Wonk**
  While Kenewendo leans on inspirational language, she easily pivots to a dissertation of facts, figures, and required reforms to advance her goals. Her tone can be authoritative, delivered in declarative statements.

- **Personal Touch**
  Kenewendo employs a highly personal and warm speaking style, openly sharing her feelings and challenges. She publicly shared that she was “eaten up” by having to keep the news of her ministerial appointment secret before it was announced.

Despite her reputation for approachability and warmth, Kenewendo stiffens when confronting controversial or inappropriate queries. She has explained that she doesn’t like “responding to the question ‘What do you bring' because I seldom hear it posed to my male colleagues.”

ON THEIR MIND

- **S&P downgrades Botswana**
  S&P Global Ratings in mid-March cut Botswana's long-term foreign and local currency sovereign credit ratings to "BBB-" from "BBB," citing structural weakness in the global diamond market that will weigh on the country's minerals-dependent economy for longer than expected.

- **Growing Fears About Fuel Supply**
  In response to public concerns about the Middle East conflict’s effect on fuel supply, Kenewendo communicated that there is no fuel crisis in Botswana. She noted that March fuel stocks are fully secured in line with national consumption requirements and that April and May fuel deliveries have already been ordered to ensure continuity of supply.

- **Copper Refinery Study at Khoemacau**
  Botswana in mid-March announced that a feasibility study will be undertaken to assess the viability of establishing a copper refinery anchored around the Khoemacau Copper Mine.

- **Bilateral Health Cooperation with United States**
  Batswana and U.S. officials signed a three-year, MOU on health cooperation in late December 2025 following the declaration of a national health emergency a few months prior. The United States plans to provide $106 million to Botswana through this three-year MOU, while the Government of Botswana is increasing its spending on its own health system by $381 million.

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NETWORK

Kenewendo, who was recognized by the World Economic Forum as a "Young Global Leader," has an impressive international network, including former Liberian President Ellen Johnson-Sirleaf and UN Deputy Secretary-General Amina Mohammed.

While she works closely with her country's international partners, she has criticized the United States, United Kingdom, European Union, and People's Republic of China for failing to accept Botswana as an "equal partner," establish balanced trade relations, or contribute to community development.

The Minister's ability to develop a strong connection to Botswana's President Duma Boko, a longtime opposition leader, exemplifies her talent for relationship-building.

Kenewendo, despite her affiliation with the former ruling party, has impressed the new president. Explaining her appointment, Boko said potential ministerial picks do not come "any better than Mme Kenewendo who is BDP (Botswana Democratic Party) as far as we know. We wanted to bring her in as far as her attributes."

CONTROVERSIES

While widely respected for her competence, Kenewendo has had to contend with accusations of favoritism and political interference.

- **Whispers About Contracts and Appointments**
  During her tenure as Minister of Investment, Trade, and Industry, Kenewendo faced accusations of favoritism in the awarding of contracts and appointments, although no concrete evidence or formal investigations supported these claims

- **Concerns about Political Interference**
  Kenewendo has been placed at the center of a controversy over the liquidation and sale of Mupane Gold Mine. Court filings allege she summoned the liquidator during the bidding process and requested access to confidential bid documents, raising concerns about improper involvement.

Kenewendo has talked openly about her experiences with sexual harassment and discrimination during her tenure as Botswana's trade minister. She had to navigate innuendos about how she got her position, fight off sexual advances, and prove herself capable despite her age and gender.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Minerals and Energy,** Government of Botswana (2024 to present)
- **Regionalization Director and Special Advisor**, UN Climate Change High-Level Champions (2022 to 2025)
- **Chairperson of the Board**, Bank Gaborone (2022 to 2025)
- **Minister of Investment, Trade, and Industry**, Government of Botswana (2018 to 2019)
- **Specially-Elected Member**, Parliament (2016 to 2019, 2024 to present)
- **Co-Founder**, Molaya Kgosi Women's Leadership and Mentorship Program (2011 to 2025)

BIO

Kenewendo's journey from rural poverty to global leadership has shaped her fierce commitment to inclusive and sustainable development. Born September 23, 1987 in the remote village of Motopi, Kenewendo has said her passion for public service was ignited early on by TV images of suffering amid plenty.

- **An International Education**
  Kenewendo pursued a degree in economics at the University of Botswana followed by a Master's Degree in international economics at the University Sussex and an executive education program at Harvard Kennedy School.

- **A Model Mentor**
  The Minister is passionate about mentorship, opining that "leadership is not about age but about impact and purpose. I want to lead by example for the youth of Africa." She co-founded the Women Leadership and Mentorship Program after meeting Michelle Obama as part of the Young African Leaders Initiative.

Kenewendo speaks English and Setswana. She enjoys activities such as travel, yoga, and hiking, which helps her manage stress. She has cited Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's novel, Half of a Yellow Sun, as a source of inspiration.

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